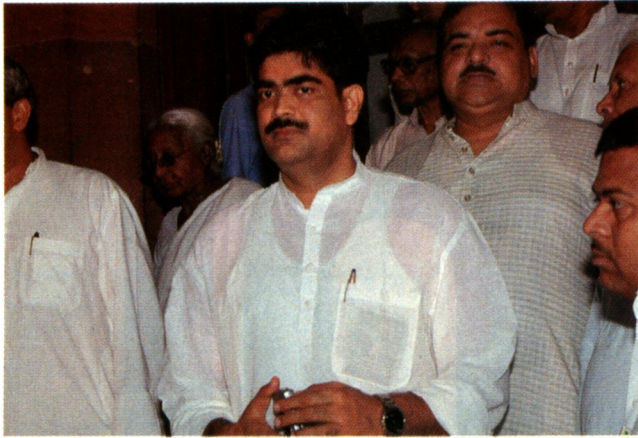




CON-NECTED: Shahabuddin

unearthed 10 extra SIM cards, 19 chargers, 15 telephone diaries, seven cell phone batteries, besides a few sharp-edged weapons and a head-phone from the convicts. A similar and simultaneous raid in Patna's Beur Jail also threw up at least a dozen cell phones.

The issue, however, invited controversy when RJD supporters went to town with Siwan sub-divisional officer's (SDO) report, which says that no cell phones were recovered from the MP's ward. The district administration has served a showcause notice to the SDO. Meanwhile, an FIR has been filed against the Siwan MP for threatening the jailer. His cup of woes, clearly, is overflowing.

by Amitabh Srivastava

Delayed Justice

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM It took nine years for a fast-track court to deliver a speedy verdict. But when it finally announced its judgement in Kerala's a high-profile sexual assault case, it exonerated A. Neelalohitadasan Nadar. The 61-year-old BSP leader, who was transport minister in the LDF Government in 1996-



FREE AT LAST: Nadar

2001, was accused by Nalini Netto, the then transport secretary, of sexually assaulting her. She had complained to the then chief minister E.K. Nayanar, who sacked Nadar in 1999. Days later, Prakrithi Srivastava, a senior Indian Forests Service officer, had also levelled similar charges against him.

In 2005, a court found Nadar guilty and sentenced him to three months imprisonment with a penalty of Rs 50,000 as compensation to Netto. Various women's groups have launched protests against the judgement. Netto, currently the chief electoral officer, said she would file an appeal. Nadar, however, is unperturbed. "I've been pleading innocent for all these years. Now it has been proven," he said soon after the verdict.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

Going the Phoney Way

PATNA Here's a wake-up call to those who had been gloating over a survey by the ASSOCHAM which declared that Bihar had registered the highest percentage growth (88.2 per cent) of mobile phone subscribers in the country. The growth may well have its roots in the state's jails.

A surprise inspection in Siwan jail—which

houses the controversial RJD MP Mohammad Shahabuddin—in the wee hours of August 31 saw the recovery of 37 mobile phones from the inmates. Seven phones were recovered from Shahabuddin's ward alone. According to Siwan SP Umesh Kumar, "the phones were hidden in a flour container kept for him". The police also

OBITUARY



Harkishan Singh Surjeet 1916-2008

It may sound anathema to the Marxists. Yet the timing of the deaths of both the CPI(M) high priests in recent times appears pregnant with some "other worldly" symbolism. E.M.S. Namboodiripad, CPI(M) general secretary, had passed away the day India's first BJP Government took office in 1996. Harkishan Singh Surjeet, his successor, died following a prolonged illness a few days after the unprecedented alliance he had initiated between the Congress and the CPI(M) was snapped. The symbolism does not end here. Surjeet became the first Indian Communist to be accorded a state funeral in Delhi. He is also responsible for the unprecedented clout the Left enjoys today. While Marxists have run coalition governments in some states for long, it was Surjeet who brought the concept to the Centre, brokering the V.P. Singh government in 1989 and then cobbling up

the H.D. Deve Gowda and I.K. Gujral-led governments in 1996 and 1997 respectively. No Communist had ever moved with such felicity through the corridors of Delhi politics as he did. Born in Bundala in Punjab's Jalandhar district, a teenaged Surjeet joined Naujawan Bharat Sabha founded by his hero, Bhagat Singh. Surjeet joined the CPI in 1939. He was one of the 32 members who walked out of the CPI in 1964 to form CPI(M). Surjeet was one of the first members of the nine-member Politburo, a position he held for 44 years. It was only when his health deteriorated that he was

relieved from the Politburo in April last year. His death comes at a time when the CPI(M) has lost the crucial key in national politics which Surjeet had entrusted it with. His passing away is much more than a symbolic loss for his organisation.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan